

Gratitude

She wears white sneakers- they're always clean, never dull old gray- and brand new jeans. She's calling someone. And then someone comes- a tall, middle-aged woman. As I watch her pass by, I see her wearing old sneakers, dull and gray. Patched jeans in the middle of a freezing November. They walk together to an old car. I follow them. The woman then asks her, "How was your day?", and she talks for a long, long time. The woman listens, remarks, laughs, and I see confetti blossoming on her face. Her wrinkles near her eye holes waver, and her laugh resembles a bright fall rhapsody. But the girl never asks the woman, "How was *your* day?". I follow them into their car. The woman drives for a long, long time. Two whole hours, while the girl sleeps in the passenger seat. The woman loves music, Christmas carols to November blues, but the radio is never turned on- for she dreads the girl might wake up. The car rolls down the highway in silence. The sun falls, yet the moon never misses the timing; the pearl gracefully rises, glistening in its time. Moonlight reflects in the woman's eyes. Her day's now gone- same as yesterday, same for a year, same since the girl was there. It's just that she couldn't remember from when. The car reaches the house. A red brick house, apple-scented with tall pine trees all around. For dinner, they eat soup. I join them at their dining table. Spicy beef soup, always warm and tasty- but a bit too spicy, for the girl loves spicy food. The girl eats her soup, full of beef. The woman eats her soup- no beef, and the soup hurts her stomach, for it is too spicy. The girl goes up to her room. Her room is always warm even in cold winter; a man had fixed all the patches in the window before he took the airplane, dreading the girl would feel cold. Before she sleeps, she calls the man. The man reminds her gently with the same old words: You can give up any time you want, we're always there. The girl nods, which the man never would see, and goes to sleep. The next morning, the woman wakes up at five, as always. She prepares breakfast and lunch for the girl to take to school. She then drives the girl to school. The woman comes back alone; the radio is on. She sings along to pop music and laughs each time the talk show guest makes a funny remark. I stay in the back seat, watching her, listening to the radio. When she reaches the red brick house, she cleans the girl's room. She goes to her bathroom and cleans the hair clogging the sewer. The girl never notices, yet she always does the same. I watch her. She hums while she fixes the rug. Finally, I ask her, "Why did you do all that for me?". She couldn't hear me. The sentence only hovers in the cold air, and it breaks down into millions and millions of pieces. She hums, and she leaves.